

Antioch 268 and Its Legacy in the Fourth-Century Theological Debates

Dragoş Andrei Giulea
Concordia University

■ Abstract

The study proposes an analysis of the concepts of *ousia* and *hypostasis* in the theology of the Council of Antioch which condemned Paul of Samosata in 268 CE. The authentic reports preserved from the assembly unveil the fact that the synodals who condemned Paul of Samosata employed the two terms interchangeably to denote the individual entity or person rather than the common essence or nature of the Father and Son. Additionally, they defended Christ's divinity before time and simultaneously assumed a certain subordinationism. The study additionally explores the *Sitz im Leben* of this theology, an accepted language embraced in the Eastern part of the Roman world in the third century. The article further traces the elements of this Antiochene theology in the fourth century in what was traditionally viewed as the "Arian" councils held in Antioch in 341 and 345 as well as in such authors as Eusebius of Caesarea and the Homoiousians. While Antioch 341 and 345 distanced themselves from Arianism, it is more coherent to interpret them, together with Eusebius and the Homoiousians, through this new hermeneutical lens, namely Antioch 268, rather than the traditional polarization between Nicaea and Arianism.

■ Antioch 268: A Forgotten Orthodoxy of the Third Century

The winter of 268–269 was cruel for the Christian community of Antioch. More than fifty bishops of the main Eastern cities of the Roman Empire arrived in their town to examine certain allegedly wrong doctrines and behaviors of the bishop of Antioch, Paul of Samosata.¹ Malchion, a Christian priest and the head of a sophist school in town, was assigned as the theologian who would interview and publicly

¹ Different sources report either 70 or 80 bishops of Syria, Palestine, and Asia Minor; see Manlio Simonetti, "Antioch," in *The Encyclopedia of the Early Church* (ed. Angelo Di Berardino; New York: Oxford University Press, 1992) 48.

debate the bishop. As the chronics attest, the bishop lost this public confrontation and the synod deposed him.² In the last act of their meeting, the synodals composed a *Synodical Letter*, which remains partially preserved to this day by Eusebius of Caesarea, and sent it to “the whole catholic Church under heaven,” especially to the two significant absent bishops, Dionysius of Alexandria and Maximus of Rome.³ Furthermore, six of the synodals addressed an epistle to Paul of Samosata himself in order to express their theological position, a document known as the *Letter of Six Bishops*.⁴ As Henri de Riedmatten argues, the documents of the council were collected in a special dossier that circulated in its authentic version until the sixth century.⁵ Consequently, it is very plausible that such fourth-century authors like Eusebius of Caesarea, Athanasius, the Homoiousians, the Cappadocians, and many of their contemporaries had access to its authentic form.

I will argue in the present study that the synod of Antioch 268 made official a metaphysico-theological position conveyed in the third century in the Eastern part of the Roman Empire. Distinct from the Nicene paradigm, this metaphysical vision apparently represented a largely accepted, “orthodox,” position in the third-century Eastern world.⁶ However, as a paradox of history, in the fourth century, it was associated with the anti-Nicene circles or alliances, traditionally called “Arian” or “semi-Arian.” I will argue that Antioch 268, treated as orthodox by all parties involved in the fourth-century controversies, exerted considerable influence at that time, at least in the Eastern part of the Christian world, and mostly within the anti-Nicene circles or alliances. More precisely, Antioch 268 implied a metaphysico-theological paradigm which was further assumed in such key “Arian” councils as Antioch 341 and 345, and Sirmium 351. Consequently, I will uphold

² See Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 7.29 (*The Nicene and Post Nicene Fathers* [ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wallace; 10 vols.; 1886–1900; repr., Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1999]), NPNF² 1:313.

³ *Ibid.*, 6.33.

⁴ The *Letter of Six Bishops* was edited by Friedrich Loofs, *Paulus von Samosata: Eine Untersuchung zur altkirchlichen Literatur- und Dogmengeschichte* (Leipzig: J. C. Hinrichs, 1924) 320–24; Gustave Bardy, *Paul de Samosate: Étude historique* (Louvain: Spicilegium Sacrum Lovaniense, 1929) 13–19, and Eduard Schwartz, *Eine fingierte Korrespondenz mit Paulus dem Samosatener* (München: Bayerischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, 1927) 42–46. The *Letter* was considered authentic by Loofs, Bardy, and Henri de Riedmatten, *Les actes du procès de Paul de Samosate: Étude sur la Christologie du III^e au IV^e siècle* (Paradosis 6; Fribourg: Éditions St-Paul, 1952) 121–34, in which de Riedmatten also dismisses Schwartz’s arguments that the *Letter* might have been a forgery.

⁵ De Riedmatten, *Les actes du procès*, 133. It is plausible that the dossier included the transcription of the dialogue between Malchion and Paul, usually called the *Acts of the Process*. Today, we have only a few debatable fragments of these *Acts* preserved in different authors and florilegia. G. Bardy, M. Richard, J. N. D. Kelly, A. Grillmeier, R. L. Sample, F. W. Norris, H. C. Brenecke, and R. P. C. Hanson doubt the authenticity of these documents, considering them an Apollinarian composition of the fourth century. To the contrary, R. Lorenz, T. D. Barnes, W. H. C. Frend, R. D. Williams, M. Simonetti, C. Stead, L. Perrone, and U. M. Lang argue for the authenticity of the fragments; see, U. M. Lang, “The Christological Controversy at the Synod of Antioch in 268/9,” *JTS* 51 (2000) 54–80, at 56.

⁶ I simply use the term “orthodox” in its general, or basic, minimal sense which denotes a normative, standard, or correct doctrine.

the thesis that the theology defended by these councils as well as by such authors as Eusebius of Caesarea (who actually supported the Nicene Council) and the Homoiousians is better understood through the lens of Antioch 268 rather than the traditional polarization between Nicaea and Arianism.

A key reference to the metaphysical assumptions of Antioch 268 is preserved in an authentic letter composed by George of Laodicea, in which he states that the fathers of Antioch understood οὐσία (substance) and ὑπόστασις (hypostasis) as denoting the individual substance. Moreover, they rejected the ὁμοούσιον (consubstantial) of Paul of Samosata, because this notion would have led to Sabellianism. It is significant for our discussion that the authenticity of George of Laodicea's report was not denied by such major pro-Nicene authors as Athanasius (*On the Synods* 43 and 45), Basil of Caesarea (*Epistle* 52.1), and Hilary of Poitiers (*On the Councils* 81) at the moment when some anti-Nicene writers argued against the Nicene ὁμοούσιον as being refuted by the council of Antioch 268.⁷ While replying to this argument, none of the aforementioned pro-Nicene theologians denied the authenticity of the report. However, all attempted to explain why the synodals of Antioch 268 rejected the term ὁμοούσιος. According to them, the conciliar fathers of Antioch employed a different meaning of the term ὁμοούσιος—and they rejected that particular meaning. To the contrary, Nicaea brought forth a new understanding of the word ὁμοούσιος, and, consequently, the Nicene position did not contradict the Synod of Antioch 268.

To be clear, the argument of the present paper does not make use of the *Acts of the Process*, a document of debated authenticity among today's scholars, but only of the authentic testimonies connected with Antioch 268. Thus, in what concerns the theological vision of the synod, George of Laodicea testifies that, in order to stress, against Paul of Samosata, the ontological separation of the Son from the Father, the synodal bishops affirmed that the Son possesses an individual ὑπόστασις.⁸ Furthermore, they maintained that the Son is also an οὐσία, which means, an individual substance.⁹ Additionally, George clearly states that, for the same fathers

⁷ See also G. L. Prestige, *God in Patristic Thought* (London: SPCK, 1959) 206–8, and John Behr, *The Way to Nicaea* (The Formation of Christian Theology 1; Crestwood, NY: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2001) 207–36, at 218–20.

⁸ See George of Laodicea, *Epistula dogmatica*, in Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.12.3: “The Son has a hypostasis, he is subsisting, and he is an existent entity, not a word, and he is called substance” (ὁ υἱὸς ὑπόστασιν ἔχει καὶ ὑπάρχων ἐστὶ καὶ ὢν ἐστίν, οὐχὶ δὲ ῥῆμά ἐστιν, οὐσίαν εἰπεῖν καὶ τὸν υἱόν). For the Greek text, see *Epiphanius III: Panarion (haereses 65–80). De Fide* (ed. Karl Holl and Jürgen Dummer; GCS 37; Berlin: Akademie Verlag, 1985) 285. Unless otherwise mentioned, translations are mine.

⁹ See George of Laodicea, *Epistula dogmatica*, in Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.12.6 (GCS 37:285): “The fathers expressly called the Son a substance” (οἱ πατέρες τὸν υἱόν, φημί, οὐσίαν ἐκάλεσαν). The same passage includes as well the relevant expression: “But being a Son, he is a substance” (ἀλλ’ υἱὸς ὢν οὐσία ἐστίν). Winrich A. Löhr similarly observes that the Homoiousian bishops convened at Sirmium in 358 invoked the Council of Antioch 268 which condemned the ὁμοούσιος as a concept leading to Sabellianism; see Winrich A. Löhr, “A Sense of Tradition: The Homoiousian

of Antioch 268, the concepts of οὐσία and ὑπόστασις refer to the same thing.¹⁰

For this reason, from the perspective of the Antiochene semantics, it is logical to reject the term ὁμοούσιος from trinitarian theology, because, within the conceptual frame of this metaphysical paradigm, this term implies the identity of the individual substances of the Father and the Son. This means that, if the Father and Son are consubstantial, they are not two but one single individual substance. As the Sabellians proclaimed, they are the same divine individual entity, “the same thing.” Consequently, Athanasius, Basil, and Hilary were right when arguing that Nicaea and Antioch employed two different meanings of the term ὁμοούσιος.

The *Letter of Six Bishops* is also a valuable document in our discussion, since it witnesses to two additional theological ideas considered orthodox in 268, as noticed by de Riedmatten in his research. While the pre-incarnate divine status of the Son is fully and clearly defended in the *Letter*, an obvious subordinationist position is also taken in order to avoid ditheism.¹¹ Furthermore, de Riedmatten observes that the *Letter* employs the term “unbegotten” or “ungenerated” (ἀγέννητος) as a fundamental divine name of the Father, “la première épithète qui convienne au Père.”¹² Thus, the *Letter* makes a traditional distinction between the ungenerated condition of the Father, called “God the unbegotten” (ὁ θεὸς ἀγέννητος), and the “generate condition of the Only-begotten Son” (τὸν υἱὸν γεννητόν, μονογενῆ υἱὸν).¹³

It is equally significant to notice that de Riedmatten compares the *Letter of Six Bishops* with the anathemas of the council of Sirmium 351 and points out the existence of some common linguistic elements and patterns of argumentation. His

Church Party,” in *Arianism after Arius: Essays on the Development of the Fourth Century Trinitarian Conflicts* (ed. Michel R. Barnes and Daniel H. Williams; Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1993) 89.

¹⁰ See George of Laodicea, *Pan.* 73.12.8 (GCS 37:285): “The fathers, therefore, called substance this hypostasis” (ταύτην οὖν τὴν ὑπόστασιν οὐσίαν ἐκάλεσαν οἱ πατέρες).

¹¹ De Riedmatten, *Les actes du procès*, 129.

¹² *Ibid.*, 122.

¹³ See *Letter of Six Bishops* 2 (Loofs, *Paulus*, 324). For further studies on the second- and third-century use of the term “unbegotten,” employed as a divine name associated with the Father, in contradistinction with the term “only-begotten,” associated with the Son, see Thomas A. Kopecek, *A History of Neo-Arianism* (Cambridge, MA: The Philadelphia Patristic Foundation, 1979) 242–66; Andrew Radde-Gallwitz, *Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nyssa, and the Transformation of Divine Simplicity* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009) 67–78; Mark DelCogliano, *Basil of Caesarea's Anti-Eunomian Theory of Names* (VCS 103; Leiden: Brill, 2010) 99–108; idem, “The Influence of Athanasius and the Homoiousians on Basil of Caesarea's Decentralization of ‘Unbegotten,’” *J ECS* 19 (2011) 197–223. As DelCogliano shows, in the fourth century, the interpretations of this distinction were radically different between anti-Nicene and pro-Nicene authors. While the former implied that the Son has to be generated and have a beginning like all the other creatures (even he is a special one), the pro-Nicenes argued that the distinction has never implied this philosophical view, that “unbegotten” may be applied as well to the Son, and generally it does not deny the unity or similarity of essence of the Son, or his eternity.

conclusion is that the *Letter* was decisively used in the redaction of the Sirmian formula and the anathemas.¹⁴

The Antiochene metaphysical position that understands οὐσία as individual substance can be easily noticed in the *Letter of Six Bishops*. In one passage, the document identifies οὐσία and ὑπόστασις as it states that the Son is the Sophia, the Logos, and the Power of God “existent before times as God not in foreknowledge but in substance and hypostasis.”¹⁵ At the end of the letter, it also states that Christ “exists in himself as one according to the substance, although he is rather known under many names.”¹⁶

Another significant element of the *Letter* is the distinction between the invisible and unknown Father and the visible Son who is his image.¹⁷ By way of consequence, humans may know of the Father only what the Son reveals to them.¹⁸

These testimonies lead us to the conclusion that the Antiochene perspective encapsulated a specific theological language and a specific metaphysics in which the terms οὐσία and ὑπόστασις refer to the individual substance of the Father or that of the Son. Nevertheless, while the divinity of the Son was clearly emphasized, the main weakness of this metaphysical language consisted in the lack of a linguistic instrument able to avoid ditheism; the *Letter* itself notes it briefly.¹⁹ For this reason, it follows logically that the authors accepted a major ontological distinction between the invisible, unknown, and unbegotten God the Father and his manifested and only-begotten divine Son. As de Riedmatten has already pointed out, this vision implies an obvious subordinationist position. Subordinationism is equally supported by their current language of angelomorphic christology (obvious in the *Letter* 4–5), a common place of the pre-Nicene age, in which the Son plays the role of the messenger of the Father and is characterized by such classical biblical expressions as “the Angel of the Lord,” “the Angel of the Father,” and “the Angel of Great Council.”²⁰ Later on, the aforementioned Council of Sirmium 351 would attempt to make official the doctrine that the Son is subordinate to the Father.²¹

¹⁴ De Riedmatten, *Les actes du process*, 131.

¹⁵ *Letter of Six Bishops* 2 (Loofs, *Paulus*, 324): πρὸ αἰώνων ὄντα οὐ προγνώσει ἀλλ’ οὐσία καὶ ὑποστάσει θεόν. See also *Letter of Six Bishops* 9 (Loofs, *Paulus*, 330).

¹⁶ *Letter of Six Bishops* 9 (Loofs, *Paulus*, 330): ἐν γὰρ καὶ τὸ αὐτὸ ὦν τῇ οὐσίᾳ, εἰ καὶ τὰ μάλιστα πολλαῖς ἐπινοίαις ἐπινοεῖται.

¹⁷ According to the *Letter of Six Bishops* 2 (Loofs, *Paulus*, 324), the Father “cannot be seen” (οὐδὲ ἰδεῖν δύναται).

¹⁸ Ibid. It is worth noting as well that the association of a more apophatic language and this epistemological vision of an unknown Father later became the theological mark of several authors from Arius to Eusebius of Caesarea, and was rejected by Eunomius, who presumed that humans were able to know the essence of the Father as much as the Son may know it.

¹⁹ *Letter of Six Bishops* 3 (Loofs, *Paulus*, 325).

²⁰ *Letter of Six Bishops* 4–5 (Loofs, *Paulus*, 326–27). For angelomorphic christology, see Charles A. Gieschen, *Angelomorphic Christology: Antecedents and Early Evidence* (Leiden: Brill, 1998).

²¹ See the eighteenth anathema of the council in Athanasius, *Syn.* 27.

■ Antioch 268 in Its Eastern Roman Context of the Third Century

Other documents of the third century seem to imply that the Antiochene metaphysical viewpoint that assumes the identity between οὐσία and ὑπόστασις was not only a local, isolated conception, but rather a more largely conveyed position that merely received its official expression at Antioch 268. For example, it is plausible that Origen himself defended the same metaphysical view: scholars like Prestige, Simonetti, Hanson, Williams, and Edwards have argued that “[f]or Origen the words ὑπόστασις (*hypostasis*), ὑποκείμενον (*hypokeimenon*) and οὐσία (*ousia*) are all synonyms for the same thing—distinct individual entity.”²² I am inclined to assume the same opinion, since in *Comm. Jo.* 2.10.75, a text preserved in its original Greek version, one can see that the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are definitely called three hypostases, while in *Comm. Jo.* 2.10.74 Origen acknowledges that the Spirit has “its own substance” (οὐσίαν τινὰ ἰδίαν) that is different from the Father’s and the Son’s, with the reason being that he is not the same thing as the Father. It is very plausible, therefore, that this meaning of οὐσία, congruent with that of Antioch 268 and differing from that of Nicaea, reflects Origen’s authentic position.

Another example is the synod against Beryllus of Bostra, a meeting that possibly took place somewhere between 238 and 244. Apparently, Beryllus, too, defended a monarchianist thesis thirty years before Paul of Samosata, while maintaining that the “Saviour and Lord did not pre-exist with his own delimitation of substance (μὴ προϋφεστάναι κατ’ ἰδίαν οὐσίας περιγροφῆν) before his sojourn among men, nor had he a divinity of his own (μηδὲ μὴν θεότητα ἰδίαν ἔχειν), but only the Father’s dwelling in him.”²³ At least the first part of the sentence, which is significant for our discussion, reflects a standpoint very close to Sabellianism: the Son did not have an individual existence before his incarnation. However, the remarkable fact is that the correct or orthodox position expressed by Eusebius is actually phrased by means of the same Origenian language from *Comm. Jo.* 2.10.74: the Son has to possess “his own substance” (ἰδία οὐσία). Thus, it is worth noting that Eusebius of Caesarea reports that Origen was the theologian invited to the council of Bostra to debate with Beryllus, and ostensibly the famous Alexandrine converted the heresiarch to the standard vision of the third century, which most likely assumed that the Son

²² See Manlio Simonetti, “Note sulla teologia trinitaria di Origene,” *Vetera Christianorum* 8 (1971) 273–307, at 286; R. P. C. Hanson, *The Search for the Christian Doctrine of God: The Arian Controversy, 318–381* (1st ed. 1988; repr. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2005) 66, who follows Prestige, *God in Patristic Thought*, 197. Likewise, Rowan Williams embraces the same opinion in his classical Arius: *Heresy and Tradition; Revised Edition* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2001) 143–44, as well as Mark J. Edwards in his *Origen against Plato* (Burlington, VT: Ashgate, 2002) 69–76. One has to mention at the same time that Christoph Marksches, *Origenes und sein Erbe. Gesammelte Studien* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2009) 174–87, and Ilaria L. E. Ramelli, “Origen, Greek Philosophy, and the Birth of the Trinitarian Meaning of *Hypostasis*,” *HTR* 105 (2012) 302–50, at 304–6, consider that Origen understood οὐσία rather as essence. Marksches, however, also follows Stead in pointing out that the word οὐσία may include other meanings or nuances than “essence,” for instance “staff,” “property,” or “special character”; see Marksches, *Origenes*, 186.

²³ Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 6.33.1 (NPNF² 1:277, slightly modified).

possessed a divine individual substance before his incarnation.²⁴ Moreover, this history adds even more plausibility to the thesis that Origen himself understood οὐσία as individual substance.

Another remarkable testimony regards Pierius of Alexandria, the head of the Alexandrine school who gained the sobriquet of “young Origen,” and who died in Rome in the first years of the fourth century.²⁵ Photius describes Pierius’s theological viewpoint in the following lines:

In regard to the Father and the Son his statements are orthodox, except that he asserts that there are two substances and two natures (οὐσίαι δύο καὶ φύσεις δύο), using these terms (as is clear from what follows and precedes the passage) in the sense of hypostasis (τῆς ὑποστάσεως), not in the sense given by the adherents of Arius.²⁶

In conclusion, it is highly plausible that the metaphysical view of Antioch 268—in which the terms οὐσία and ὑπόστασις were used as synonyms and denoted the individual substance—was not only an isolated local standpoint but a widely spread theological language and a metaphysical assumption accepted as orthodox in the Eastern or Greek-speaking context of the Roman world in the second half of the third century. In spite of the fact that, following Nicaea, it was associated with the Arians and anti-Nicene groups,²⁷ this vision was not heretical in the third century. Indeed, it received its official expression at the Synod of Antioch in 268. Consequently, the Antiochene theology of 268 most likely represented the orthodoxy of the time, at least in the Eastern part of the Roman Empire, as George of Laodicea plainly stated that this language actually represented the “Eastern” parlance.²⁸ In modern times, Manlio Simonetti strengthens this thought by asserting that the understanding of οὐσία as individual substance was prevalent in pre-Nicene Eastern theology.²⁹

We will further see that the metaphysics of οὐσία and ὑπόστασις assumed by the synodals of Antioch in 268 coincided with the fourth-century positions of Eusebius of Caesarea, of the *Dedication Creed*, and of the fourth creed of Antioch 341, which was subsequently taken over in many other creedal formulas of the fourth century. Additionally, the Homoiousian alliance made a direct connection between their position and Antioch 268. In conclusion, we discover in Antioch 268 probably the most influential synod of the third century. As no other synod before Nicaea contradicted the metaphysical view of Antioch 268, it is most likely that Eusebius, the subsequent Antiochene councils, as well as the Homoiousians regarded this

²⁴ Eusebius, *Hist. eccl.* 6.33.2.

²⁵ Jerome, *Vir. ill.* 76.

²⁶ Photius, *Lex.* 119.93a-b. English translation by John H. Freese, *The Library of Photius* (London: SPCK, 1920) 209. For the Greek text, see René Henry, *Bibliothèque: Texte établi et traduit* (Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 1959) 100.

²⁷ See, for instance, Rowan D. Williams, “The Logic of Arianism,” *JTS* 34 (1983) 56–81.

²⁸ Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.16.1 (GCS 37:288).

²⁹ Manlio Simonetti, *Studi sull'arianesimo* (Rome: Editrice Studium, 1965) 168.

understanding of οὐσία as the genuine orthodox and traditional metaphysics. The following pages will further argue for this case.

It is worth making the observation at this point that the meaning of “orthodoxy” or the “normative” in the third century was slightly different than the one in the fourth century.³⁰ Beyond the subjective aspect in which all the authors of the time (e.g., Nicene, Arian, Homoiousian) envisioned themselves as orthodox, there are certain objective features. During the fourth century, a new meaning was gradually taking shape and becoming dominant, namely that a certain theological idea was expected to be declared orthodox in a general council and then gradually assumed throughout the whole Roman Empire. As Christianity did not know the phenomenon of ecumenical councils before 325, the term “orthodox” in the third century seemingly implied a more local theological expression, of more limited authority, however supposedly concordant with other coexisting accepted theological languages. Thus, Antioch 268 was one admitted language among others, “one orthodoxy” concomitantly accepted with other standard formulations. The Western and Latin speaking part of the Roman Empire, for instance, preserved its own trinitarian language and its metaphysics inherited from Tertullian’s age, which coexisted with the Greek one(s). We may use the plural, since it is also possible that, in the Greek speaking world prior to Nicaea 325, two languages and understandings of οὐσία circulated in parallel, at least in the 320s.

■ Antioch 268 and Its Legacy in the “Heretical” Antiochene Councils Subsequent to Nicaea 325

Although Nicaea is perhaps the most prominent name when we generally think of the Christian history of the fourth century, the city of Antioch was arguably the most active theological center. In the fourth century, no fewer than seventeen councils took place in the city, compared to only fourteen in Alexandria, thirteen in Rome, nine in Carthage, seven in Constantinople, and seven in Milan. These numbers reflect the significant influence the city played in all the major debates of the time. Although not all of the seventeen Antiochene councils defended a unique and constant doctrine, and while some of them were focused more on administrative matters, we may, nevertheless, notice a certain reoccurrence of and preference for the metaphysical and theological paradigm assumed in 268.³¹

A few councils held in Antioch in the 320s and 330s (for instance, in 327, 330, and 332) did not approach theological issues but rather defined a political identity in opposition to Nicaea. Likewise, in 338/9 Antioch made a new anti-Nicene political move in a council that enthroned Gregory of Cappadocia as the bishop

³⁰ I am indebted to the anonymous reviewer for this observation.

³¹ As exceptions we may count, for instance, the synod summoned by Meletius of Antioch in 363, which paradoxically accepted the Nicene creed (Acacius of Caesarea was also present). However, a new council held in Antioch in 367 would refute the Nicene creed again, and reestablish the creed of Antioch 341. Another exception is the council of Antioch 378, which assumed a Homoiousian position.

of Alexandria. In response, Pope Julius summoned a council in Rome in 340 declaring Athanasius as the legitimate bishop of Alexandria. Additionally, Julius asked his Eastern counterparts to send a delegation to Rome in order to discuss the disagreement on Athanasius and Marcellus of Ancyra.

In response, in 341, with the occasion of the dedication of the church of the Holy Concord in Antioch, Emperor Constantius convened a synod in the city with the intention of outlining a common theological vision of the Eastern Empire.³² However, the Nicene party regarded it as a “heretical Arian” meeting. Among the key participants we find Flacillus of Antioch, Eusebius of Nicomedia, and Acacius of Caesarea, as well as Basil of Ancyra and George of Laodicea (the two future leaders of the Homoiousian alliance).³³ While the synod most likely elaborated only a single formula of faith, its historical dossier includes four formulas, as three other documents were added to the main creed.

Thus, the first formula seems to be part of a significant message (perhaps part of a letter) from the ninety synodal bishops, who manifest their indignation that the pro-Nicene party of Athanasius and Julius considers them “followers of Arius.” The Eastern bishops underline the traditional and even apostolic character of their theology by asserting that they did not “receive any other faith beside that which has been handed down from the beginning.”³⁴ However, they do affirm that they verified Arius’s faith and “admitted him,” which contradicts their refutation of the main Arian tenets in the second document. Yet Arius’s theology contradicts another remarkable element of this letter, namely, Christ’s existence with the Father “before all ages.”³⁵

The second document of Antioch 341 is actually the real creed of the council, also known as the *Dedication Creed*. Here, the bishops equally profess their “evangelical and apostolic tradition” and Christ’s divinity: “God from God . . . perfect from perfect . . . the indistinguishable image of the Father’s godhead, substance, will, power, and glory . . . God the Logos.”³⁶ This formula may be based on one of Asterius the Sophist’s expressions: “God from God, indistinguishable image of the substance, will, power, and glory.”³⁷ It is worth mentioning that the description of the Son as the “indistinguishable Image of the Father,” as we will also see in the following pages, starts playing a key role in the Antiochene trend.

³² See Sara Parvis, *Marcellus of Ancyra and the Lost Years of the Arian Controversy 325–345* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2006) 162–63.

³³ For the list of participants, see Parvis, *Marcellus of Ancyra*, 260.

³⁴ Athanasius, *Syn.* 22 (NPNF² 4:461).

³⁵ *Ibid.*

³⁶ See, Athanasius, *Syn.* 23.3: τῆς θεότητος οὐσίας τε καὶ βουλῆς καὶ δυνάμεως καὶ δόξης τοῦ πατρὸς ἀπαράλλακτον εἰκόνα. For the Greek text, see Hans-Georg Opitz, ed., *Athanasius Werke* 2/7. *De synodis Arimini et Seleucia* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 1935) 249.

³⁷ See Asterius, *Fr.* 10.4–5: θεὸς θεόν, οὐσίας τε καὶ βουλῆς καὶ δυνάμεως καὶ δόξης ἀπαράλλακτον εἰκόνα; Greek text in Markus Vinzent, ed., *Asterius von Kappadokien. Die theologischen Fragmente* (VCS 20; Leiden: Brill, 1993) 86.

Moreover, as Mark DelCogliano has shown, while the term ἀπαράλλακτος (indistinguishable) was consecrated by the Stoics, it was Origen who applied it to describe the relationship between the Father and the Son.³⁸ While the term was used by the Nicenes to assert that the Son was the “indistinguishable Image of the Father,” Asterius and the synodals of Antioch 341 describe the Son as the “indistinguishable Image of the Father’s οὐσία.”³⁹

One may even find a rare incipient trinitarian formula, “three in hypostasis and one in *symphonia*”;⁴⁰ and it is again, most likely, Origen’s thought at the roots of this terminology.⁴¹ Furthermore, the Father and the Son have different οὐσῆαι and different hypostases, which shows a definite continuity with the Antiochene metaphysical vision of 268. The council, therefore, develops a certain proper christology within the Anthichene metaphysical matrix, in which the Son is the exact or indistinguishable image of the Father’s substance and exists in συμφωνία (symphony, consonance) with him.

While the third formula is part of a self-exculpation letter of one of the bishops, the fourth creed of Antioch 341 was composed a few months later by only a few of the bishops, and was articulated in an even more reconciling tone.⁴² They both clearly state the divinity of the Son and his generation before all ages from the hypostasis of the Father. A significant historical fact is that the fourth creed would come to exert a tremendous influence in the Eastern anti-Nicene councils, as it would be taken over as the main formula of the councils of Serdica 343, Sirmium 351 and 358, Seleucia 359 as well as Antioch 345 (in the celebrated *Ekthesis Makrostichos*), 358, and 367.⁴³ Winrich Alfried Löhr observes that the fourth creed

³⁸ See Mark DelCogliano, “Eusebian Theologies of the Son as the Image of God before 341,” *JECS* 14 (2006) 459–84 at 468–69.

³⁹ *Ibid.*, 479, n. 43.

⁴⁰ Athanasius, *Syn.* 23.3 (*Athanasius Werke* 2/7:249): τῇ μὲν ὑποστάσει τρία, τῇ δὲ συμφωνίᾳ ἓν. See also *Oratio III contra Arianos* 10 (a document sometimes associated with Athanasius, but of debated authorship), in which the Son is also characterized as “consonant in everything” (ἐν πᾶσιν ἔστι σύμφωνος) with the Father (*Athanasius Werke* 1/1/3. *Oratio III contra Arianos* [ed. Karin Metzler and Kyriakos Savvidis; Berlin: De Gruyter, 2000] 317), as well as Fr. 72 of Marcellus, who reports that Asterius affirmed that the Father and the Son “harmonize in everything” (ἐν πᾶσιν συμφωνοῦσιν) and have a strict consonance/harmonization in all words and works (διὰ τὴν ἐν πᾶσιν λόγοις τε καὶ ἔργοις ἀκριβῆ συμφωνίαν); see Marcellus, *Fragmenta*, in *Eusebius Werke IV. Contra Marcellum, De ecclesiastica theologia* (ed. Erich Klostermann and Günther C. Hansen; GCS 14; Leipzig: J. C. Hinrichs, 1906) 198.

⁴¹ Stuart G. Hall notes that Origen was the first to make a similar assertion; Hall, *Doctrine and Practice in the Early Church* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1991) 142. Thus, the Alexandrine was probably the first to affirm that the Father and the Son are two distinct hypostases but one in terms of “harmony” or “symphony” (τῇ συμφωνίᾳ) and will (*Cels.* 8.12; SC 150:200).

⁴² See Athanasius, *Syn.* 24–25. For modern commentators, see Hanson, *The Search*, 291; Manlio Simonetti, *La crisi ariana nel quarto secolo* (Rome: Institutum patristicum Augustinianum, 1975) 164; and Kopecek, *A History of Neo-Arianism*, 73.

⁴³ See, for instance, Winrich A. Löhr, *Die Entstehung der homöischen und homöianischen Kirchenparteien: Studien zur Synodalgeschichte des 4. Jahrhunderts* (Bonn: Wehle, 1986) 10–21. It is worth noting especially his opinion that, “die ‘4.antiochenische Formel’ wurde das dominierende

of Antioch 341 became the orthodox formula of the Eastern synodals of Serdica 343, and accepted three divine ὑποστάσεις while envisioning οὐσία and ὑπόστασις as synonyms.⁴⁴ Consequently, the assembly commonly shared with the council of Antioch 268 the metaphysical paradigm of οὐσία and ὑπόστασις, a sensible subordinatianist position as well as the idea of eternal generation of the Son. Once more, the continuity with the metaphysics of Antioch 268 is obvious.

As a last note about Antioch 341, which was an anti-Nicene council, one may remark that the synodals were distinctly aware of a set of positions associated with Arianism, and they strongly refuted them in the documents. Thus, the *Dedication Creed* concludes with a few anathemas against those who assert that the Son is a creature or that there was a time or age before the generation of the Son.⁴⁵ As Henson affirms, the *Dedication Creed* “deliberately excludes the kind of Arianism professed by Arius and among his followers by Eusebius of Nicomedia.”⁴⁶ This awareness of their separation from Arianism and the clear rejection of the Arian positions should be a sufficient reason to understand that the theology of Antioch 341 cannot be interpreted through the lens of Arian theology, or through the classical polarized difference between Nicenes and Arians. Thus, the synodals of Antioch 341 were neither Nicenes nor Arians in their theological vision. It is also worth noting that not all pro-Nicene authors characterized the bishops of Antioch 341 as Arians, as Athanasius did. Hilary of Poitiers, for example, an obvious pro-Nicene author, declared this council a *sanctorum synodus*.⁴⁷ We may conclude, therefore, that the theological vision of Antioch 341 needs a more appropriate description by means of a new hermeneutical key, and I submit that the metaphysics of Antioch 268 is the best candidate.

Another key Antiochene council took place in 345 and articulated a symbol of faith known as the *Ekthesis Makrostichos* (The Long-lined Creed). This new

Synodalbekenntnis im Osten” (idem, 13); likewise, “Zum Erweis der ‘Orthodoxie’ der orientalischen Bischöfe ist dem Synodalschreiben die sogenannte ‘4. antiochenische Formel’ angefügt.” (idem, 21). Hanson confirms this position while stating that the fourth creed of Antioch 341 “was destined to be used for nearly fifteen years as the basis for all other creeds which were designed to be ecumenical” (*The Search*, 292). In the same way, Mark DelCogliano and Andrew Radde-Gallwitz assert that it became the “standard creed in the East for more than twenty years and was reissued at many subsequent eastern councils”; see “Introduction” to *Basil of Caesarea: Against Eunomius* (Washington, DC: CUA Press, 2011) 27.

⁴⁴ Löhr, *Die Entstehung*, 18. Hanson (*The Search*, 292) makes a similar remark: “[T]he only possible interpretation of *hypostasis* as used in the anathema is that it is meant to be identical with *ousia*: any other interpretation would make this out to be a flagrantly Sabellian statement.”

⁴⁵ Ibid. If Eusebius of Nicomedia signed this document, then he made a doctrinal step forward from the Council of Nicaea 325, when he apparently signed the creed but not the attached anathemas, which refuted the same positions with the *Dedication Creed*; see the *Letter of Recantation*—preserved in Socrates, *H.E.* 1.14 and Sozomen, *H.E.* 2.16—which Eusebius of Nicomedia and Theognis of Nicaea wrote from exile in 327, asking the emperor to allow their return. Antioch 341 seems to represent a certain progress in Eusebius’s public acknowledgment of the divinity of the Son.

⁴⁶ Hanson, *The Search*, 290.

⁴⁷ Hilary of Poitiers, *Syn.* 32.

formula actually reproduces the fourth creed of Antioch 341 (in which οὐσία and ὑπόστασις are used as synonyms denoting an individual substance), and it adds seven long commentaries. The same stress on the divinity of the Son before his incarnation may be noticed here as well as the use of the term ὑπόστασις as individual existence. The fourth annexed commentary includes the thought that the distinction between the “unbegotten” (ἀγέννητος) Father and the “generated” and “only-begotten” Son implies the subordination of the Son, an idea previously asserted in the 320s by Arius, Eusebius of Nicomedia, and Asterius.⁴⁸ However, the *Makrostich* specifies that the Son is generated before the ages and is a “perfect God according to nature.”⁴⁹ In the same paragraph, the text further avows that the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are three things (πράγματα) and three persons (πρόσωπα), which clearly manifests another incipient trinitarian language.

Consequently, the above data prove that the main metaphysical and theological assumptions of Antioch 268 were reassumed and further refined in the theology of the emblematic Antiochene creeds of 341 and 345. In so doing, the two councils, alongside the writings of the authors who defended a similar position, actually developed the metaphysical Antiochene paradigm on a higher level of theorization and theological refinement, and, in this way, they strengthened a theological legacy still vivid within the anti-Nicene contexts of the 360s.

The Antiochene legacy of 268 had a direct relationship, too, with the councils held at Sirmium in the 350s, as the second council of Sirmium 351 took over the fourth formula elaborated at Antioch 341. As we have already seen, de Riedmatten shows that the anathemas of Sirmium 351 reveal the direct influence of Antioch 268. Moreover, the third council of Sirmium (357) was confirmed by a council of Antioch in 357, while the fourth council of Sirmium (358) was confirmed by a new council held in Antioch in the same year. Due to these strong ties between Antioch and Sirmium, it is worth taking a look at the theology of these Sirmian councils of the 350s.

While the creed of Sirmium 351 and its third anathema clearly assert the divinity of the Son before all ages, its first anathema condemns (in the spirit of Antioch 341) those who entertain the idea of a time when the Son was not, and of the Son being begotten either from nothing or from an other ὑπόστασις than that of the Father.⁵⁰

⁴⁸ For Arius, see his *Letter to Eusebius of Nicomedia* (preserved in Theodoret of Cyrus, *H.E.* 1.5) and his confession sent to Alexander (preserved in Athanasius, *Syn.* 16); for Eusebius, see below his *Letter to Paulinus of Tyre* (preserved in Theodoret of Cyrus, *H.E.* 1.5), and the formulation of the axiom that it is impossible to have two unbegotten principles, the Father and the Son; for Asterius, see *Fr.* 3, 12, 44 (in Vinzent, *Asterius von Kappadokien*, 82, 88, 108 respectively).

⁴⁹ Θεὸν κατὰ φύσιν τέλειον εἶναι, in Athanasius, *Syn.* 26 (*Athanasius Werke* 2/7:252).

⁵⁰ See Athanasius, *Syn.* 27 (*NPNF* 2 4:464): “But those who say that the Son was from nothing or from other subsistence (ἐξ ἑτέρας ὑποστάσεως) and not from God (μὴ ἐκ τοῦ Θεοῦ), and that there was a time or age when He was not, the holy and catholic church regards as aliens.” For the Greek text, please see *Athanasius Werke* 2/7:254.

It is also worth observing the way they use the term οὐσία, because doing so will unveil what they believed its meaning to be. Thus, the sixth and seventh anathemas assert that, while generating the Son, the Father's divine οὐσία is neither dilated nor contracted, because it is immaterial. This realistic language of dilation and contraction can be used only with regard to individual objects and not with regard to an abstract essence. Hence, the Father's οὐσία cannot denote an abstract essence but his concrete individual entity or substance. Thus, the underlying argument in this context is that the Son's generation from this concrete individual substance should not be understood as the generation of a material or sensible individual entity—which implies contraction, dilation, or change—but as a divine generation which is beyond space, matter, and change, because the Father's divine substance is not material and composed, and cannot be divided, dilated, or contracted.

Since the Father and the Son are two divine ὑποστάσεις or οὐσίαι, the problem of avoiding ditheism was perceived as urgent in this setting. Thus, while the Sirmian bishops distanced themselves from Arianism (as the synodals of Antioch 341), it is also remarkable that they struggled to find an appropriate position between Arianism and ditheism. Their optimal solution was to stress the distinction between the unbegotten Father and the only-begotten Son, and the subordination of the latter. The anathema 26 is particularly illustrative while chastising “whoever asserts that the Son is without cause and unbegotten, as if maintaining two realities without cause and two unbegottens, hence making two Gods.”⁵¹ The argument clearly assumes that the quality of being “unbegotten” (ἀγέννητος) belongs exclusively to God the Father, and that declaring the Son equally unbegotten will lead to the absurd conclusion of accepting two Gods. Consequently, the Son, in spite of being divine, cannot be unbegotten. And this ontological condition definitely makes him subordinate to the Father, an idea again clearly and officially stated in the eighteenth anathema (as it was at Antioch 345). As a last note, Basil of Ancyra, the future leader of the Homoiousian alliance, was one of the key theologians of this synod.

In conclusion, we can identify a certain Antiochene metaphysical and theological trajectory, already present in the genuine documents of Antioch 268, and further assumed and refined at Antioch 341, 345, and Sirmium 351. One may further count three common theoretical standpoints commonly assumed by the three councils: the meaning of οὐσία and ὑπόστασις understood as individual substance (not abstract essence), Christ's divinity before ages, as well as a certain subordination to the Father (officially expressed at Antioch 345 and Sirmium 351). Through the mediation of the fourth Antiochene creed of 341, this paradigm was largely accepted in some main anti-Nicene councils, groups, and theoretical positions of the fourth century.

With this context in mind, it is not surprising that certain scholars have already envisioned, for instance, the creeds of Antioch 341 as expressing a widely accepted

⁵¹ Athanasius, *Syn. 27* (*Athanasius Werke* 2/7:256): τις ἀγέννητον καὶ ἀναρχον λέγοι τὸν υἱόν, ὥς δύο ἀναρχα καὶ ἀγέννητα λέγων καὶ δύο ποιῶν θεούς.

position of the Christian East in the fourth century. Kelly, for example, considers the *Dedication Creed* “frankly pre-Nicene in its tone”⁵² and “a faithful replica of the average theology of the Eastern Church, the theology of which Eusebius of Caesarea was a spokesman.”⁵³ In the same vein of thought, Hanson avows that “[t]he Second Creed shows us [the views of] the hitherto silent majority . . . they constituted a widespread point of view, but we can hardly call them a party”;⁵⁴ thus, the *Dedication Creed* “represents the nearest approach we can make to discovering the views of the ordinary educated Eastern bishop who was no admirer of the extreme views of Arius but who had been shocked and disturbed by the apparent Sabellianism of N[icaea].”⁵⁵ More recently, Gwynn makes the fundamental remark that the theology of the *Dedication Creed* cannot be fully understood within either a Nicene or Arian theological frame, but as a third viewpoint:

It is possible to define the ‘Dedication Creed’ not through comparison to ‘Arianism’ or ‘Nicene orthodoxy’, but as a broadly representative statement of a theology that prevailed in much of the eastern Church in the first half of the fourth century, and indeed beyond. At the Council of Seleucia in 359, it was this creed and not Nicaea that those eastern bishops now usually known as the ‘Homoiousians’ invoked as the traditional faith of the Church.⁵⁶

I submit that one can make the same assertions about the fourth creed of Antioch 341, later taken over in the main Eastern synods up until 367, and considered orthodox not only by the aforementioned anti-Nicene theologians and councils, but also by a pro-Nicene theologian such as Hilary. The large Eastern conveyance of this theological vision cannot be understood without a common tradition as its background. In the light of the above investigation, I submit that the largely shared Eastern background of the fourth century was built on the forgotten “orthodoxy” of the third century, which was epitomized and officially expressed at the council of Antioch 268.

■ Eusebius of Caesarea: A Theology in the Matrix of Antioch 268

De Riedmatten has already noticed that certain elements of the *Letter of the Six Bishops*—a few particular expressions and arguments as well as the subordinationist theology and the biblical texts employed by the subordinationists—make it closer to Eusebius of Caesarea than to Origen or Apollinarius.⁵⁷ Eusebius of Caesarea

⁵² J. N. D. Kelly, *Early Christian Creeds* (2nd ed.; London: A. and C. Black, 1960) 271.

⁵³ *Ibid.*, 274.

⁵⁴ Hanson, *The Search*, 291.

⁵⁵ *Ibid.*, 290.

⁵⁶ David M. Gwynn, *The Eusebians: The Polemic of Athanasius of Alexandria and the Construction of the “Arian Controversy”* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007) 225. For a survey of the impressive influence of the council of Antioch 341 in the subsequent debates and councils of the fourth century, see Gustav Bardy, *Recherches sur saint Lucien d’Antioche et son école* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1936) 96–119.

⁵⁷ See de Riedmatten, *Les actes du process*, 127 and 129.

has been portrayed in modern scholarship as “a great Origenist” and “the most influential church leader of the early fourth century.”⁵⁸ Scholars have also noticed the significant influence he exercised on the Cappadocians, especially on Basil of Caesarea. As a result, in the last two decades, Eusebius has become one of the most researched authors of the formative era between the councils of Nicaea and Constantinople.⁵⁹

In this particular study, my argument is that, in spite of signing the creed of Nicaea 325, on the one hand, and defending Arius and Asterius, on the other, Eusebius should not be interpreted either as an Arian or a Nicene theologian. To the contrary, I submit that a more appropriate hermeneutical key for understanding his theological vision should be the legacy of Antioch 268. The aforementioned central theological elements of Antioch 268—the concepts of οὐσία and ὑπόστασις understood as individual substances, the eternal generation of the Son, and a sensible subordinationism—are also central tenets of Eusebian theology.⁶⁰

We will further see that, in spite of being a key supporter of the Nicene council, Eusebius assumed a metaphysical vision on the divine οὐσία which is identical with the one defended by the synodal bishops of Antioch 268 and Antioch 341, and therefore distinct from the position defended by Athanasius and the Cappadocians. This dual attitude may also reflect his effort to re-conciliate the Antiochene and Nicene theological visions. However, our inquiry will lead us to the conclusion that Eusebius’s metaphysical assumption, according to which the meaning of the term οὐσία denotes an individual entity, logically conflicts with the Nicene ὁμοούσιος, in spite of his attempt to harmonize them within the frames of a common theological vision.

Eusebius equally draws a logical conclusion within the semantic frame of Antiochene metaphysics: if the term οὐσία denotes an individual entity, particularly each divine entity, then the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit represent in fact three divine οὐσίαι. According to Eusebius, the Son and the Father are distinct entities in “substance and power” (οὐσία τε καὶ δυνάμει) as an image is a distinct reality

⁵⁸ See Christopher A. Beeley, *The Unity of Christ: Continuity and Conflict in Patristic Tradition* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2012) 49.

⁵⁹ See, for instance, Holger Strutwolf, *Die Trinitätstheologie und Christologie des Euseb von Caesarea. Eine dogmengeschichtliche Untersuchung seiner Platonismus rezeption und Wirkungsgeschichte* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1999); Marina S. Troiano, “Il *Contra Eunomium* III di Basilio di Cesarea e le *Epistolae ad Serapionem* I–IV di Atanasio di Alessandria: Nota comparativa,” *Aug* 41 (2001) 59–91; Lewis Ayres, *Nicaea and its Legacy: An Approach to Fourth-Century Trinitarian Theology* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004) 221; Stephen M. Hildebrand, *The Trinitarian Theology of Basil of Caesarea: A Synthesis of Greek Thought and Biblical Truth* (Washington, DC: CUA Press, 2007) 80, n. 10; Mark DelCogliano, “Basil of Caesarea on Proverbs 8:22 and the Sources of Pro-Nicene Theology,” *JTS* 59 (2008) 183–90; Sabrina Inowlocki and Claudio Zamagni, eds., *Reconsidering Eusebius: Collected Papers on Literary, Historical, and Theological Issues* (Leiden: Brill, 2011); Beeley, *Unity of Christ*.

⁶⁰ See, for instance, Simonetti, *Studi sull’arianesimo*, 102, and Colm Luibhéid, *Eusebius of Caesarea and the Arian Crisis* (Dublin: Irish Academic Press, 1981) 20–40.

from its archetype: “Indeed the image and the model are not considered one and the same thing, but two substances, and two realities, and two powers.”⁶¹ Engaging philosophical terminologies from Aristotle, Numenius, and Porphyry, Eusebius defines the Logos as a second substance after the Father. The meaning of the phrase “second substance” should not be understood in an Aristotelian technical sense as “secondary substance,” namely, as species or genus, but rather as “second primary substance,” simply as denoting the Son as a distinct, separate individual entity, an individual divine οὐσία distinct from the unbegotten οὐσία of the Father.⁶²

Aiming to express this ontological distinction between the substance of the Father and the substance of the Son, Eusebius primarily defines the Father by means of two patterns of thought echoing Origen’s language. Thus, the substance of the Father is conceived as beyond any definition or language; it is an incorporeal substance, beyond words and linguistic expressions.⁶³ Likewise, he is “prior to a principle, older than a first, of earlier being than a monad, mightier than every name, unspeakable, ungraspable, good, cause of all, maker, beneficent, foreseeing, saving, himself one and only God of whom all things are, through whom all things are”;⁶⁴ his divinity is unbegotten as well.⁶⁵ Eusebius’s negative language associated with the Father also matches that of the Antiochene tradition. Furthermore, again in an Origenian pattern of thought, he even affirms that the Father is “beyond substance” (ἐπέκεινα οὐσίας)⁶⁶ and defines him as the “unmanifested and invisible mind” (τὸν ἀφανὴ καὶ ἀόρατον νοῦν).⁶⁷

Unlike the Father, the Son is a second divine substance begotten of the first without deprivation, diminution, severance, or division.⁶⁸ Eusebius protests against

⁶¹ Marcellus, *Fr.* 82 (GCS 14:203).

⁶² See Eusebius, *Praep. ev.* 7.12.2: “with the uncaused and unbegotten substance of the Father of everything . . . [there is] a second divine substance and power” (μετὰ τὴν ἀναρχον καὶ ἀγένητον τοῦ θεοῦ τῶν ὅλων οὐσίαν . . . δευτέραν οὐσίαν καὶ θεϊαν δύναμιν). For the Greek text, see Édouard des Places, ed., *Eusèbe de Césarée. La préparation évangélique* (SC 215; Paris: Cerf, 1975) 222; see also Eusebius, *Praep. ev.* 7.15.6 (SC 215:238).

⁶³ See Eusebius, *Eccl. theol.* 2.6.2 (GCS 14:103): “of an incorporeal substance, beyond words and linguistic expression” (τῆς ἀσωμάτου καὶ ἀλέκτου καὶ ἀνεκφράστου οὐσίας). For Origen, see, e.g., *Cels.* 6.64 and 7.45.

⁶⁴ Eusebius, *Dem. ev.* 4.1.5; see also Luibhéid, *Eusebius*, 30.

⁶⁵ Eusebius, *Dem. ev.* 4.3.13; 4.6.3; *Hist. eccl.* 1.3.13.

⁶⁶ Eusebius, *Praep. ev.* 11.21.6. For the Greek text, see Édouard des Places, ed., *Eusèbe de Césarée. La Préparation évangélique, Livre XI* (SC 292; Paris: Cerf, 1982) 156.

⁶⁷ See Eusebius, *Eccl. theol.* 2.17.6 (GCS 14:121).

⁶⁸ Eusebius, *Dem. ev.* 4.3.11. For the Greek text, see Ivar A. Heikel, ed., *Eusebius Werke VI. Demonstratio euangelica* (GCS 23; Berlin: J. C. Hinrich, 1913) 154: οὐτι πω κατὰ στέρησιν ἢ μείωσιν ἢ τομῇν ἢ διαίρεσιν (“not by deprivation, or diminution, or severance, or division”); 4.3.13 (GCS 23:154): οὐ κατὰ διάστασιν ἢ τομῇν ἢ διαίρεσιν ἐκ τῆς τοῦ πατρὸς οὐσίας προβεβλημένον; see also 4.15.52 (GCS 23:181), 5.1.8 (GCS 23:211), 5.1.9 (GCS 23:211).

the Arian idea that the Son was created *ex nihilo*.⁶⁹ Under this aspect, Eusebius emphasizes that, in the divine generation, “[the Father begot a Son] made like Him in all respects” ([ὁ πατὴρ ἐγέννα υἱὸν] κατὰ πάντα ἀφωμοιωμένον αὐτῷ), and the Son was “made like his Father in all respects” (τῷ αὐτοῦ πατρὶ κατὰ πάντα ἀφωμοιωμένος).⁷⁰ Likewise, Eusebius obviously defends the divinity and separate individual existence of the Logos by defining him as “another God in himself” (ἕτερον ἐν αὐτῷ θεόν; *D.E.* 5.4.4), “a second God” (ὁ δὲ δεύτερος; *D.E.* 5.4.9), a “second Lord of all” (δεύτερος τῶν ὅλων κύριος; *D.E.* 6.15.2), a “second cause” (δευτέρου αἰτίου; *D.E.* 5.*Præf.*20), “having a different substantial substratum” (ἕτερον ἔχουσα τὸ κατ’ οὐσίαν ὑποκείμενον; *D.E.* 5.1.21), and “possessing his own substance” (καθ’ ἑαυτὸν οὐσιωμένος; *D.E.* 4.3.4). Finally, Eusebius qualifies even the Holy Spirit as a third substance.⁷¹

Corroborating the data, we realize that, while assuming the metaphysical principles of the Antiochene tradition, Eusebius was concomitantly a supporter of Nicaea. However, the modern reader realizes, too, that he interpreted Nicaea and the ὁμοούσιος in a particular and surprising manner, distinct from Athanasius, the Cappadocians, and other pro-Nicene theologians. In the letter to his diocese of Caesarea, he presents himself simultaneously as a genuine defender of the Nicene council and its creed, and he strives to assure his community that the council did not contradict their inherited tradition. Nevertheless, the old adage *non idem est si duo dicunt idem* matches perfectly in his case. Eusebius comments on the creed and his accepting the Nicene formula in the following way:

To this interpretation of the sacred doctrine which declares that the Son is of the Father, but is not a part of his substance (μέρος αὐτοῦ τῆς οὐσίας), it seemed right to us to assent. We ourselves therefore concurred in this exposition; nor do we cavil at the word “*homoousios*” having regard to peace,

⁶⁹ See Luibhéid, *Eusebius*, 23. For the orthodoxy of Eusebius’s Christology, see Christopher Beeley, “Eusebius’ *Contra Marcellum*: Anti-Modalist Doctrine and Orthodox Christology,” *ZAC* 12 (2009) 433–52.

⁷⁰ Eusebius, *Eccl. theol.* 3.21.1 (GCS 14:181) and 2.14.21 (GCS 14:118). See also Eusebius, *Eccl. theol.* 1.10.1 (GCS 14:68), 2.17.3 (GCS 14:120), and *Marc.* 1.14.35 (GCS 14:25): τῷ πατρὶ ὁμοιώτατος. At the same time, as Lienhard shows, Eusebius regards the Father and the Son as distinct in terms of substances, functions, and ranks, for example in Eusebius, *Eccl. theol.* 2.7 and 2.23; see Joseph T. Lienhard, *Contra Marcellum: Marcellus of Ancyra and Fourth-Century Theology* (Washington, DC: CUA Press, 1999) 120.

⁷¹ Eusebius, *Praep. ev.* 7.15.6 (SC 215:238). To mention other anti-Nicene names who used a similar position, one of the fragments preserved from Marcellus of Ancyra unveils that Narcissus, the bishop of Neronias, believed with Eusebius of Caesarea that there are not only two substances, but even three; see Marcellus, *Fr.* 116. For the Greek text, see Markus Vincent, ed., *Markell von Ankyra: Die Fragmente, Der Brief an Julius von Rom* (VCS 39; Leiden: Brill, 1997) 108. It is worth noting that, according to Vaggione, Eunomius apparently developed a similar system of three οὐσίαι, while affirming in his *Apologia Apologiae* 1.2a: “Our whole doctrine is summed up in the highest and principal essence, in the essence which exists through it but before all others, and in the essence which is third in terms of origin and the activity which produced it” (*Eunomius: The Extant Works* [ed. Richard P. Vaggione; Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1987] 102).

and fearing to lose a right understanding of the matter. On the same grounds, we admitted also the expression “begotten, not made:” “for *made*,” said they, “is a term applicable in common to all the creatures which were made by the Son, to whom the Son has no resemblance.” Consequently, he is no creature like those which were made by him, but is of a substance far exceeding any creature (κρείττονος δὲ ἢ κατὰ πᾶν ποίημα τυγχάνειν οὐσίας); which substance the Divine Oracles teach was begotten of the Father (ἦν ἐκ τοῦ Πατρὸς γεγεννήσθαι) by such a mode of generation (τοῦ τρόπου τῆς γεννήσεως) as cannot be explained nor even conceived by any creature (πάσῃ γεννητῇ φύσει).⁷²

The argument makes it very plausible that Eusebius did not envision οὐσία as an essence or common substance but as an individual, actual entity; real, but not material. For this reason, one can understand his constant concern that some people might think of the generation of the Son in a corporeal fashion as long as, in the material world, a generated substance is an object of the universe which possesses parts and can be divided. But the passage shows that Eusebius conceived of the substance of the Father as beyond matter and generation, while the Son’s generation from the Father has to be immaterial and ineffable, surpassing the generation of any created entity. Thus, he struggles to assure his readers that the generation of the Son should not be envisioned as a division of the Father’s substance, or as subtracting a part of it, because the substance of the Father is unbegotten, and therefore of a different nature (φύσις) than those of all the objects of the universe:

Thus also the declaration that “the Son is consubstantial (ὁμοούσιον) with the Father” having been discussed, it was agreed that this must not be understood in a corporeal sense, or in any way analogous to mortal creatures; inasmuch as it is neither by division of substance (κατὰ διαίρεσιν τῆς οὐσίας), nor by abscission nor by any change of the Father’s substance and power (οὐσίας τε καὶ δυνάμεως), since the unbegotten nature (τὴν ἀγέννητον τοῦ πατρὸς φύσιν) of the Father is inconsistent with all these things.⁷³

Nevertheless, the main challenge that Eusebius faces in his metaphysics of two οὐσίαι—in which the first one generates the second—is to secure the authentic divinity of the second substance, namely, the Son. If the Father is God and a

⁷² Eusebius, *Ep. Caes.*, 10–11. For the Greek text, see Hanns C. Brennecke, ed., *Athanasius Werke 3/1. Dokumente zur Geschichte des Arianischen Streites* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2007) 45; English translation: *NPNF*² 2:11 (italics in original).

⁷³ Eusebius, *Ep. Caes.* 12 (*Athanasius Werke* 3/1:45); trans., *NPNF*² 2:11. See also *Ep. Caes.* 7 (*Athanasius Werke* 3/1:44); trans., *NPNF*² 2:11: “[The emperor] exhorting all present to give them their assent, and subscribe to these very articles, thus agreeing in a unanimous profession of them, with the insertion, however, of that single word ‘*homousios*’ (consubstantial), an expression which the emperor himself explained, as not indicating corporeal affections or properties; and consequently that the Son did not subsist (ὑποστῆναι) from the Father either by division or abscission: for he said, a nature which is immaterial and incorporeal (τὴν ἄυλον καὶ νοεράν καὶ ἀσώματον φύσιν) cannot possibly be subject to any corporeal affection.”

different entity or substance than the Son, how is it possible to maintain that the Son is also God, instead of a creature? We have seen before that Eusebius actually calls the Son “another God in himself” (ἕτερον ἐν αὐτῷ θεόν; *D.E.* 5.4.4]) and “a second God” (ὁ δὲ δεύτερος; *D.E.* 5.4.9). Thus, his solution is to secure a highly accurate similarity of the Son with the Father through a certain firm expression able to communicate this high accuracy of likeness: “in every respect like (κατὰ πάντα τρόπον ἀφωμοιωῖσθαι) the Father” or “like his Father in all respects” (τῷ αὐτοῦ πατρὶ κατὰ πάντα ἀφωμοιωμένος). As Lewis Ayres puts it, each of these expressions becomes a “cipher” attempting to secure the divinity of the Son, the fact that the Son cannot be associated with any created being but only with the Father, and that his accurate similarity would necessarily imply his divinity:

That he is consubstantial with the Father then simply implies, that the Son of God has no resemblance to created things, but is in every respect like (κατὰ πάντα τρόπον ἀφωμοιωῖσθαι) the Father only who begat him; and that he is of no other hypostasis or substance (ὑποστάσεως καὶ οὐσίας) but of the Father.⁷⁴

Once more, we may notice, in this passage, that Eusebius identifies οὐσία and ὑπόστασις, and asserts the existence of two or three οὐσίαι or ὑποστάσεις. Obviously, οὐσία denotes an individual substance. Nevertheless, it is noticeable, too, that Eusebius’s theology encompasses a logical fallacy. His attempt to harmonize the Antiochene traditional metaphysics of οὐσία understood as individual substance with the Nicene ὁμοούσιος generates an ad-hoc, inconsistent theory. From a logical point of view, if one assumes that the term οὐσία denotes an individual entity, then the term ὁμοούσιος signifies either an identity of substance between the Father and the Son (in the sense that the Father and the Son are the same entity, as Sabellius claimed), or a class of gods.⁷⁵ Consequently, since each of the two options is theologically unacceptable, the term ὁμοούσιος is not logically compatible with the Antiochene metaphysical vision, as the synodals of Antioch 268 had intuited at their time. Yet, it cannot be congruent with any of Eusebius “ciphers,” as he hoped. The Nicene ὁμοούσιον belongs to a different metaphysical paradigm, in which οὐσία is understood as common essence, the nature which individual entities share or participate in. Because the Nicene ὁμοούσιον cannot coexist with the Antiochene metaphysics within the same coherent system, tritheism remains one of the main challenges of Eusebius’s vision.

⁷⁴ Eusebius, *Ep. Caes.* 13 (*Athanasius Werke* 3/1:45–46); trans., *NPNF*² 2:11. Compare with the expression τῷ πατρὶ κατὰ πάντα ὅμοιον εἶναι appearing in the *Macrostich* formula of 345, in Athanasius, *Syn.* 26.6 (*Athanasius Werke* 2/7:253).

⁷⁵ And this is what the other anti-Nicene writers—from Arius to Asterius, to Eusebius of Nicomedia, to Aetius, to Eunomius, to the Homoiousians—realized, and they subsequently opposed the Nicene ὁμοούσιος in order to preserve the metaphysics of οὐσία as individual substance, which they probably considered philosophically more accurate and historically more traditional.

■ Homoiousians: Reshaping Antioch 268 after Eusebius

Another theological vision articulated within the same metaphysical frame found in Eusebius of Caesarea and the legacy of Antioch 268 was developed by the Homoiousian alliance, which exercised a significant influence after 358. Moreover, as we will see, the Homoiousians themselves claimed that legacy. While their position has sometimes been misinterpreted through a Nicene lens, I will argue that they too should be read through the paradigm developed from Antioch 268.⁷⁶ Beyond the well-known *iota*, which now and then occasioned even justified ironies, the Homoiousian vision appears to be almost indistinct from the pro-Nicene position.⁷⁷ In contradistinction, if we realize that the main difference between Homoiousians and pro-Nicenes was the way they conceived of the divine substance, the difference between the two groups will make their positions and arguments much more clear, distinguishable, and reasonable.

Two letters preserved in Epiphanius's *Panarion* 73 represent the key extant Homoiousian documents. Basil of Ancyra and George of Laodicea, the leaders of this alliance, most likely composed the two letters and disclosed in an obvious way that they understood the Father and Son as two distinct οὐσίαι, two distinct individual substances.

The first document, the synodal epistle of the Council of Ancyra 358, starts the defense of the Homoiousian position with the following general biologicophilosophical principle: "Every 'father' is thought to be the father of a substance like his own (ὁμοίας οὐσίας αὐτοῦ)." ⁷⁸ Frank Williams translates this sentence

⁷⁶ I am not the first to assert that Homoiousians understood οὐσία as individual substance. Simonetti maintains the same thing in his *Studi sull'arianesimo*, 169. Likewise, Hubertus Drobner affirms the following about Basil of Ancyra: "Er verstand unter οὐσία eine individuelle Substanz, so daß er in der Gottheit drei ὑποστάσεις und drei οὐσίαι vertrat." See H. Drobner, *Lehrbuch der Patrologie* (Freiburg: Herder, 1994; repr. Frankfurt: Peter Lang, 2004) 243.

⁷⁷ For the main literature on the topic see J. Gummerus, *Die homöusianische Partei bis zum Tode des Konstantius. Ein Beitrag zur Geschichte des arianischen Streites in den Jahren 356–361* (Helsinki: A. Deichert, 1900); Jeffrey N Steenson, "Basil of Ancyra and the Course of Nicene Orthodoxy" (PhD diss., Oxford University, 1983); Löhr, *Die Entstehung*; idem, "A Sense of Tradition"; Timothy Barnes, "A Note on the Term Homoiousios," *ZAC* 10 (2007) 276–85; Barnes shows that the term ὁμοιούσιος occurs in the summer of 358 at the council of Sirmium (see Barnes, "A Note," 283) and disappears in the synodal acts subsequent to 360 (idem, 285). Nevertheless, the term comes out later, in 378, when Macedonians hold a council in Antioch/Caria, and apparently refute the Nicene ὁμοούσιον, while proposing instead the term ὁμοιούσιος (see Sozomen, *H.E.* 7.2; Socrates only confirms the event in *H.E.* 5.4).

⁷⁸ Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.4.2. For the Greek text, see Karl Holl and Jürgen Dummer, ed., *Epiphanius III. Panarion* haer. 65–80; *De fide* (GCS 37; Berlin: Akademie-Verlag, 1985) 273. As DelCogliano shows, Homoiousians were influenced by Athanasius's arguments regarding the theological importance of the term "Father" (which is relative and implies a Son) and diminished the importance of the concept of unbegotten (see "The Influence of Athanasius"). However, Athanasius, the Homoiousians, and Basil of Caesarea preserve the distinction between "unbegotten" and "only-begotten." Yet, the generation of the Son does not imply his lack of divinity but his eternal co-existence with the Father (see Basil, *Eun.* 2.17).

by rendering οὐσία in the Nicene sense as essence, or common substance.⁷⁹ However, it does not make logical sense to affirm that a father or a mother gives birth to an essence like theirs, in other words, to a human-ness. To the contrary, it makes more sense to assert that a father or a mother gives birth to an individual substance like them, therefore to a child who is a human individual like them. From this biological observation about generation and substance, Basil proceeds to the argument regarding the generation of the Son as a different οὐσία than that of the Father: “It is obvious, therefore, from the natural observations, that the ‘Father’ does not mean the Father of an activity, but of a substance like himself (ὁμοίας οὐσίας αὐτοῦ), of a hypostasis with a proper activity (τῆς κατὰ τὴν τοιάνδε ἐνέργειαν ὑποστάσεως).”⁸⁰ Hence, it is most likely that he identifies οὐσία and ὑπόστασις in this sentence in an obvious Antiochene fashion.

The same individual understanding of οὐσία is encountered in the following sentence: “Thus, while being generated similar in substance (ὅμοιος κατ’ οὐσίαν) with the Father who generated him, the Son will not bring his substance (οὐσίαν) to the identity (εἰς ταυτότητα) with the Father, but to similarity or likeness (ἐπὶ τὴν ὁμοιότητα).”⁸¹ One of the anathemas added at the end of the synodal letter makes a traditional Aristotelian distinction between a substance and its activity, and subsequently criticizes those who think that the Son is like the Father only in terms of activity and not as a substance, too.⁸²

The second document, most likely composed by George of Laodicea, similarly argues that the Son is not just a word, as Paul of Samosata maintained, but a substance. George further asserts that the bishops who criticized Paul at the Council of Antioch in 268 also called the Son a “substance.”⁸³ And the Laodicene, too, makes the distinction between substance and activity and affirms that the Son is a substance.⁸⁴ It is equally evident in the text that George agrees with the same fathers of the Council of Antioch 268, who identified οὐσία and ὑπόστασις, particularly in the following sentence: “the fathers considered οὐσία as identical with ὑπόστασις.”⁸⁵

⁷⁹ See *The Panarion of Epiphanius of Salamis: Books II and III (Sect 47–80, De fide)* (trans. Frank Williams; Leiden: Brill, 1994) 347: “Every ‘father’ is understood to be the father of an essence like his.”

⁸⁰ Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.4.4 (GCS 37:273). For an analysis of the terms οὐσία and ἐνέργεια in Basil’s vision, see Steenson, *Basil of Ancyra*.

⁸¹ Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.9.7 (GCS 37:280).

⁸² Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.11.2 (GCS 37:282): “giving only the likeness of activity and not of substance” (μόνην τὴν κατ’ἐνέργειαν ὁμοιότητα διδούς τῆς κατ’οὐσίαν).

⁸³ See George’s assertion in note 8, preserved in Epiphanius’s *Pan.* 73.12.6.

⁸⁴ Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.12.6 (GCS 37:285): “But the Son, being the Logos, is not the speaking activity of God, but being a Son means that he is a substance” (ὁ δὲ υἱός, λόγος ὢν, οὐχὶ ἐνέργεια λεκτικὴ ἐστὶ τοῦ θεοῦ, ἀλλ’ υἱὸς ὢν οὐσία ἐστίν). See also Simonetti’s similar interpretation of the text in his *Studi sull’arianesimo*, 169.

⁸⁵ Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.12.8 (GCS 37:285): ταύτην οὖν τὴν ὑπόστασιν οὐσίαν ἐκάλεσαν οἱ πατέρες.

To identify the referent of the two terms, we must observe that, true to the Antiochene tradition, the Homoiousians employ the term ὑπόστασις to refer to the three divine persons. As mentioned above, George situates himself within the Eastern tradition going back to Antioch 268, and qualifies as the “Eastern” parlance the identity of οὐσία and ὑπόστασις understood as denoting the individual substance.⁸⁶ As a last observation, Homoiousians do not consider that the Father and Son share a common substance (οὐσία), nature (φύσις), or divinity (θεότητα), rather all are different and similar, because the Son is “similar in all respects” (ὅμοιος κατὰ πάντα) to the Father, as George constantly asserts.⁸⁷

As Simonetti observes, the strict identification (*rigida identificazione*) between οὐσία and ὑπόστασις in Homoiousian theology did not allow them to accept the Nicene ὁμοούσιον.⁸⁸ Likewise, in order to avoid the inclusion of the Son among the creatures, Homoiousians conceived of the generation of the Son as a special generation, described as “according to the substance” (ὅμοιος κατ’ οὐσίαν).⁸⁹

I submit that Homoiousians developed a theological vision which carried on the orthodoxy of the third century expressed at Antioch 268, and they tried to avoid both the metaphysical and theological problems that they identified in the other positions and solutions. While they distanced themselves from the problematic standpoints associated with Arius (as early as their signing of the formulas of Antioch 341 and Sirmium 351), they also realized, unlike Eusebius of Caesarea, that the Nicene ὁμοούσιον cannot cohabitate, within a single and coherent theological system, with their Antiochene metaphysical assumptions. If οὐσία is an individual substance, then ὁμοούσιος would imply either a class of gods or, in Sabbellian fashion, that the Father is the same entity with the Son. Consequently, if the substance of the Father and the substance of the Son denote two distinct individual entities, then the relationship between them cannot be of identity or class but only of “similarity” or “likeness” (ὁμοίωσις).

For all the above reasons, they rejected the Nicene ὁμοούσιον and defended the expression ὅμοιος κατ’ οὐσίαν (similar according to the substance). However, if we think that, ultimately, Homoiousians, too, intended to secure the genuine divinity of the Son, like Athanasius and the pro-Nicenes, then we may affirm with Athanasius that the real difference between them was only a matter of words; I would say, of metaphysical vocabulary. Unfortunately, over centuries, the Athanasian adage has induced the simplistic idea that the difference between pro-Nicenes and Homoiousians was only that of an iota. But this simplistic interpretation fails in discerning the deeper philosophical game of the debate. They were actually two theological visions founded on two radically different metaphysical assumptions and, because of these different assumptions, their solutions encompassed dissimilar

⁸⁶ Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.16.1 (GCS 37:288).

⁸⁷ Epiphanius, *Pan.* 73.15.1;4-5; 73.18.8.

⁸⁸ Simonetti, *Studi sull’arianesimo*, 169.

⁸⁹ *Ibid.*, 171–77.

logical strengths and weaknesses. While Homoiousianism, and more generally the Antiochene paradigm, was able to make a clear ontological difference between the individual entities of the Father and the Son, the Nicene ὁμοούσιον did not possess the linguistic capacity to sufficiently emphasize their ontological separation as two distinct individual entities. To the contrary, while the Nicene ὁμοούσιον succeeded in its intention to express the divine nature's community between the Father and the Son, the Homoiousian concept of "likeness" was not able to secure it. And it was for this reason that Homoiousians proposed such supplementary conditions as the Son's special kind of generation, or the stipulation that the "likeness" should be "accurate" or "indistinguishable" (ἀπαράλλακτος). It is worth mentioning that other theologians who assumed the Antiochene paradigm, too, proposed a similar theology of "likeness" and certain additional stipulations of the relationship of "likeness" between the Father and the Son: while Eusebius of Caesarea advanced the phrase "alike in everything" (κατὰ πάντα ἄφωμοιωμένος) and Asterius used "indistinguishable image" (ἀπαράλλακτος εἰκόν) and "accurate symphonia" (ἀκριβῆ συμφωνία), the Makrostich formula of 345 ("similar in everything"—ὅμοιος κατὰ πάντα) was taken over by George of Laodicaea and the Sirmian meeting of 358. One may conclude, therefore, that fundamentally Homoiousianism did not advance a new metaphysical paradigm, but rather carried on and further refined the previous Antiochene vision, while trying to avoid Eusebius of Caesarea's philosophical contradictions. Unlike Eusebius, they realized that the metaphysics of οὐσία, understood as individual substance, cannot logically coexist with the notion of ὁμοούσιος.

■ Concluding Remarks

The above investigation has unveiled the character and influential legacy of a metaphysico-theological position developed in the second half of the third century in the Eastern provinces of the Roman Empire. According to this metaphysical standpoint, the notions of οὐσία and ὑπόστασις connote an individual entity rather than a common essence or nature; applied to the Father and the Son, οὐσία and ὑπόστασις denote each of the two individual divine persons. Apparently, this metaphysics represented an accepted, normative formula among others at the time, and received the official confirmation at the council of Antioch 268. It is very plausible that Origen, too, was one of its supporters.

In its reception history, this metaphysics exerted a significant influence in the Antiochene councils subsequent to 325, and generally in the theological discussions of the seminal years of the fourth century. Consequently, this metaphysics was considered as an accepted, orthodox, theological vocabulary at Antioch 268, and perceived likewise as the true tradition by Eusebius of Caesarea, the Homoiousians, and the synodals of Antioch 341 and 345, and Sirmium 351 (three main "Arian" councils of the fourth century). As a matter of fact, this doctrine of the third century

would become a catalytic metaphysics for many of the anti-Nicene alliances of the next century, traditionally identified as “Arian,” or “semi-Arian heretics.”

Two of the main creeds of the fourth century—namely the fourth creed of Antioch 341 and the *Ekthesis Makrostichos* of Antioch 345, both classically described as “Arian”—preserved an obvious doctrinal continuity with the theology of Antioch 268. Other dogmatic standpoints defended at Antioch 268, such as the eternal divinity and existence of the Son and his definite subordination to the Father, were also carried on, or even clearly stated, by those who assumed this legacy. If we notice, too, that these councils actually expressly refuted the set of positions associated with Arianism—namely, that the Son was a special creature, and there was a time or age before the generation of the Son—we discover their firm continuity with the “forgotten orthodoxy” of Antioch 268.

Furthermore, while christological and trinitarian debates of the fourth century have been typically interpreted through the lens of a polarization between normative Nicenes and heretical Arians, our findings suggest that the Antiochene theological paradigm developed in the third century may be regarded as another theoretical pole in these controversies. And, in this light, it is seemingly more appropriate to interpret the theological positions developed at the Antiochene councils of 341 and 345, as well as the views of such authors as Eusebius of Caesarea and the Homoiousians through this new hermeneutical lens, namely, the Antiochene theology of 268 and its third-century orthodoxy, rather than through the texts and doctrinal views pertaining to Arius and his companions.